

DAY 3, 09:00–10:00

Recap: data analysis and results interpretation

SORT IT Module 3 • Data analysis and interpretation of results • Timor-Leste

ACTIVITY 10 • 15 minutes

The Recap Quiz

1. Teams of four. Paper and a marker each
2. I read the question. You have 30 seconds
3. Hold up your answer on three
4. Scores on the flipchart. There is a prize.

Yesterday, in three lines

- Know your variable — before you calculate anything
- Choose the right average — mean lies when data are skewed
- State your denominator — every percentage, every time

Today

From numbers to meaning

Calculating is the easy part. Interpretation is the job.

Describing is not interpreting

Describing — not enough

- “Treatment success was 78.8%.”
- “8.9% were lost to follow-up.”
- “The result was significant ($p < 0.05$).”
- Your reader can read the table themselves.

Interpreting — what we want

- Compares it to something
- Explains what might be causing it
- Admits what could be wrong with it
- Says what should change, and who should do it

The four questions that turn a number into a finding

- So what? — why should a busy programme manager care?
- Compared to what? — the target, last year, another district, the literature
- Could it be wrong? — small denominator, missing data, bias, chance
- What changes on Monday? — name the action and name who takes it

“The results were significant.”

This sentence tells your reader nothing at all.

Retire these phrases

Instead of...	Write...
"The results were significant."	"Success was 9 points lower in women (73.5% vs 82.6%, $p = 0.23$) — large enough to matter, too small a sample to be sure."
"More research is needed."	"Whether decentralised drug pick-up reduces these losses should be tested before national scale-up."
"The data showed..."	"We found..." (data do not show things — you found them)
"There was a correlation."	"X was associated with Y." (keep 'caused' for experiments)

Three interpretation traps

- Confusing statistical and operational importance — significant can be trivial, and non-significant can be vital
- Claiming cause from association — use ‘was associated with’
- Interpreting what you never measured — if a third of your HIV statuses are unknown, the missing data are your finding

Say It In Plain Words

1. Your team gets one result from the practice data
2. Leg 1: explain it in ONE sentence to a District Health Officer
3. Leg 2: pass it on — next team adds what should change
4. Leg 3: pass again — third team says why it might be wrong
5. Banned words: significant, correlation, 'the data show'

“Among [who, N] in [where, when] we found [result].
This is [higher/lower] than [comparison].
A likely explanation is [reason], although [limitation].
This suggests [who] should [do what].”

The interpretation sentence. Fill it in for every main result.

Where this goes next

- 10:30 — Communicating your results to different audiences
- 11:00 — Lecture 6: structuring your written report
- 13:30 — Lecture 7: structuring your oral presentation
- Everything you wrote this morning is the first draft of your discussion section

**Describing a number is not interpreting it.
Your reader can read the table themselves.**

Say what it means. Say what should change. Say who should do it.